

Sound Formats

MP3

Because of its inherent versatility, portability and swap-value, the MP3 is most popular format by far. However, compared to newer formats, MP3 clearly shows up as inferior. It provides very decent sound quality at high bit rates, but the quality drops audibly at lower bit rates. This means you cannot hope to have small files with premium audio quality.

Ogg Vorbis

An open source music format, Ogg Vorbis has plug-ins for popular applications such as Winamp and Sonique. It supports multi-channel streams, so you can encode a surround sound recording, and not just 2-channel stereo. However, this format is popular only within the geek circles and open source zealots, much like MP3 in its early days. Ogg Vorbis offers better audio quality at smaller file sizes as compared to MP3.

This is the ideal format if you are developing an application—such as chat, game sound, etc.—that needs audio compression. Do remember that you need to pay to use this Codec in business applications. This format is most suited to small developers.



WMA

This is Microsoft's own audio format that is part of the Windows Media family of audio and video codecs. In its latest incarnation of WMA 9, the format offers audio quality superior to MP3 at comparable bit rates, and can do much better at smaller file sizes. Since it is the native format for Windows Media Player, it is conveniently accessible.

If you choose to encode your music to WMA 9, be sure to uncheck the option to 'Copy protect music', or you will not be able to play the encoded file on any other PC or device.

AAC

An encoding scheme owned by Dolby, this is the preferred codec for the highest quality compressed audio. At low bit rates, it out-performs all other known codecs. However, Dolby has been very slow with its licensing, hence there is a dearth of good encoding tools. If you do need to play AAC files, you can download the Winamp Plug-in from www.audiocoding.com.

Apple is using AAC in the newly launched iTunes online audio shop, and its iPod player is one of the early adopters of this format, though it is currently only supported on a Mac.

Future Of MP3 Players

The future holds a lot of promise for MP3 players. Today many of these players double as watches or storage devices. Even PDAs and cell phones ship with MP3 players!

One thing we'll certainly see is a tremendous increase in memory. Today, solid-state MP3 players are bundled with 128 MB, but with the introduction of the iPod from Apple (which has as much as 30 GB storage space), one will not need to load new music for awhile! This is just the beginning; in future we'll have MP3 players with as much as 40 to 60 GB storage that will connect wirelessly to your desktop to transfer music.

With the advent of wireless standards such as Bluetooth and widespread use of RF-based PC peripherals, soon there will be receivers bundled with MP3 players too to talk with PC using RF signals.

Manufacturers are also integrating support for other standards like Ogg Vorbis, WMA and AAC into one player. Formats like Ogg Vorbis are free and don't require

manufacturers to pay a licence fee. This format is a product of the open source movement and since it's as good in quality as the MP3 format, it's widely used online and has increasing support from media players like Winamp.



Designs will also change for the better. MP3 players of the future could be worn on the wrist. A more radical design revamp for the CD MP3 player involves the introduction of 8 cm CDs to replace the existing 12 cm CDs. This makes the players more compact, but play time is reduced by almost 50 per cent.

A new breed of players hitting the market—like the Creative MuVo—is the size of a finger but stores 128 MB of songs. It also works as a portable storage device. Other designs include a cassette that can be used as both MP3 player and cassette in a regular home audio system. In the not-too-distant future, don't be amazed to see an MP3 player integrated into your beloved's diamond ring!



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